

Hacker bait

Most home users use peer-to-peer sharing applications, such as KaZaA and eDonkey, which require you to share a part of your drive. Effectively, what you are doing is closing all your doors, and opening a window. Hackers can exploit these vulnerabilities, especially if you configure your firewall to automatically allow the peer-to-peer sharing application to access the Net. You should configure your firewall to ask everytime an application wants to access the Internet.

McAfee Personal Firewall Plus:

This firewall has a tabbed view with three tabs—Summary, Internet Applications and Events. Summary gives a comprehensive list of all the frequently blocked addresses that occurred on your PC. It also gives a pie chart of the most frequently blocked ports. The Summary tab provides graphical information about the recent global port activity and an activity map displaying the level of world-wide malicious activity from Hacker-Watch.org. Strangely though, it does not display a graph of your local port activity and Internet traffic. Internet Applications gives a complete list of the applications that have tried to access the Net and their status (blocked or allowed). The Events tab gives particulars of all network activity along with the date, time, Source IP, Hostname (for Windows machines only) and event info. A simple drop-down box provided in the status bar lets you change your security level with the click of a mouse. It blocked Open Ports from running inside Internet Explorer, but failed to stop it from uploading results to the server.

Price: \$44.95 ■ **System requirements:** Windows 98, ME, 2000, or XP, 8 MB free hard drive space, Microsoft Internet Explorer 5.0 or higher, ■ **Web site:** www.mcafee.com ■ **Grade:** A-

Analysis:

All the firewalls tested gave decent protection against port scans, and many of them were able to detect that the scanning application was nmap. While all the top firewalls came with embedded objects protection, it didn't matter, as can be seen from the embedded objects test results. However, Norton Personal Firewall disabled the internal netstat command from showing any results due to which Open Ports failed to give any useful results. In terms of resource utilisation, ZoneAlarm was the least memory intensive inspite of having more features. On the configuration front, both ZoneAlarm and Norton were excellent, but ZoneAlarm was much easier to configure than Norton Personal Firewall 2003. While majority of the firewalls graphically represented the current Internet traffic, some of them even displayed a graph showing the recent attack history. Immediately after installation, both ZoneAlarm and Norton Personal Firewall 2003 came with wizards that helped you set up the firewalls. But configuring the firewalls later was easier in ZoneAlarm. In particular, the rule based filtering rules in Norton Personal Firewall 2003 is slightly complex, and could confuse a novice user. Updating was inbuilt and automated in almost all the firewalls except for Windows XP Internet Connection Firewall, which had to be updated using the standard Windows updating mechanism.

Overall, ZoneAlarm Pro was the winner, followed by Norton Personal Firewall. 

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1/2 page Ver AD